to receive aid from the US and UK.[66] And Indian resentment only deepened when that aid did not come at the scale and with the speed expected.

The Substance of Alignment?

In spring 1963, noting the China threat, Nehru complained to Galbraith that the US response on the military assistance front seemed too "studious and deliberate." He did not just have to worry about the threat but also accusations that his government was not doing enough to meet it. Galbraith also highlighted the criticism from Nehru's left flank about the value or effectiveness of the tilt toward the US. Given the slow pace of American aid decisions, there were also increasing questions about US reliability.

Galbraith warned that the US would lose momentum in India as the sense grew that Washington was reluctant to aid India because of political considerations at home and Pakistani reaction abroad. He noted that some in India were making the argument that there was no point in making concessions on Pakistan because the US was unlikely to aid India anyway. The ambassador argued that Washington needed to act on the long-term aid question.[67]

Washington knew that it had to make some decisions. Komer, citing the serious long-term threat from China, urged Kennedy to consider in the near future providing India further military aid, defense production assistance, and support to rebuild its air force.[68] The president, on his part, believed that the US would "have to move fairly soon" on this additional aid and air defense.[69] And Rusk admitted that whether the India-Pakistan talks failed or succeeded, the US "would still need to be in a position to give India some assistance against Chinese communist pressure."[70] At an April meeting, McNamara noted that cost-wise the US would not find it difficult to develop a package involving air defense and short-term defense production assistance. He, however, pointed out a key problem: the US did not even have a clear sense from India of its long-term needs.[71]

India's sense of its defense requirements was different from that of the US. Delhi envisioned a total military assistance program of $1.6 billion over five years—which later even B. K. Nehru admitted was "totally unrealistic."[72] In the US, there was consensus that this was too much. For the Kennedy administration, it was crucial that India meet both the external and the internal challenge from China—and stay afloat—and thus it wanted